AJP Policy Document

The Future of Zoos and Aquariums

The Animal Justice Party (AJP) advocates for a fundamental reorientation of zoos and aquariums away from entertainment-driven models toward facilities that exist to serve the interests of animals themselves. Facilities that currently exhibit animals for public display must transition toward roles centred on rescue, veterinary care, rehabilitation and, where necessary, the provision of lifelong sanctuary.

Where animals cannot be returned to the wild, their environments must be designed to approximate natural conditions as closely as possible, prioritising autonomy, social needs and behavioural expression. Public access, if permitted, must be strictly managed to ensure that it does not compromise animal wellbeing.

The AJP recognises that many species are not suited to captivity under any circumstances. As such, the long-term objective is to significantly reduce and, where appropriate, eliminate the keeping of animals in traditional zoo settings. Technological alternatives, particularly immersive and virtual experiences, should replace the use of live animals for education and entertainment.

Key Objectives:

1. **Transition to Animal-Centred Models**
   Phase out practices that prioritise exhibition and profit, supporting the evolution of zoos and aquariums into rescue, rehabilitation and sanctuary-focused facilities.

2. **Restrict New Zoo Establishments**
   Prohibit the establishment of new private zoos and aquariums. In exceptional circumstances where approval is considered, require rigorous pre-licensing assessments, including detailed evaluation of operator suitability, financial capacity and contingency planning for animal care.

3. **End Breeding for Display**
   Ban captive breeding except where it forms part of independently assessed conservation programmes that demonstrably benefit both species survival and individual animal welfare.

4. **Euthanasia Standards**
   Clear distinction between euthanasia conducted in an animal's best interests and that undertaken for management reasons, so that healthy animals are never killed due to management failure or financial constraints.

5. **Mandatory Exit and Transition Planning**
   Require all facilities to maintain legally enforceable exit strategies that specify how animals will be rehomed, transferred or cared for in the event of closure or operational change.

6. **Financial Assurance Requirements**
   Introduce mandatory financial assurance mechanisms to ensure that adequate funds are available for the ongoing care, relocation or rehabilitation of animals if a facility ceases operation.

7. **Develop Exit Pathways for Existing Animals**
   Implement coordinated strategies to relocate animals currently held in zoos and aquariums to accredited sanctuaries or appropriate environments wherever feasible.

8. **Promote Non-Exploitative Alternatives**
   Support the development and accessibility of virtual reality and other immersive technologies as humane alternatives to live animal displays.

9. **Strengthen Transparency and Accountability**
   Mandate full disclosure of animal origins, health status and life histories and prohibit the commercial import and export of live animals for profit.

10. **Regulate Sanctuaries**
    Establish clear legal definitions and accreditation systems to distinguish genuine sanctuaries from commercial enterprises, ensuring animal interests are paramount.

11. **Enhance Welfare Standards**

Introduce stringent, enforceable welfare standards, particularly for animals exposed to public viewing, recognising the stress associated with human interaction.

12. **Prohibit Animal Performances**
    Ban the use of animals in performances, displays or interactive experiences that compromise their wellbeing.

13. **Redirect Public Investment**
    Prioritise support for wildlife rescue organisations, veterinary services, and rehabilitation programmes over traditional zoos.

14. **Support Ethical Transition Pathways**
    Provide assistance to operators seeking to transition toward non-exploitative models, including the adoption of virtual and educational alternatives.

15. **Promote Ethical and Sustainable Practices**
    Encourage facilities to align all operations, including food provision, with principles of animal justice and environmental sustainability through adopting plant-based options.

Background and Rationale

Zoos and aquariums may unintentionally communicate that it is acceptable to confine wild animals in small or unsuitable enclosures - sometimes in isolation from their own species - for human education or entertainment. Yet such conditions can cause significant harm, as many animals are unable to engage in their natural, species specific behaviours.

The AJP's approach is grounded in the moral significance of individual animals. Whilst biodiversity and ecosystem protection are important, they must not be pursued at the expense of the lives and wellbeing of individual sentient beings. Practices such as forced breeding, confinement in inadequate conditions and the treatment of animals as interchangeable components of conservation strategies are ethically indefensible.

Effective conservation must prioritise the protection and restoration of natural habitats. Without suitable environments for animals to return to, captive breeding programmes offer limited value and may, in some cases, perpetuate harm. Moreover, zoos tend to

favour highly visible or charismatic species,[1] neglecting the broader ecological relationships necessary for functioning ecosystems.

The AJP envisions a future in which human engagement with animals is guided by respect, responsibility and non-exploitation. Transforming zoos and aquariums is a critical step toward this goal, ensuring that animals are no longer used for entertainment purposes, but are instead protected as individuals with intrinsic value.

Defining Zoos and Sanctuaries

Facilities that house animals vary widely in purpose and practice, often using overlapping terminology that obscures important ethical distinctions.

- **Zoos and aquariums** are typically commercial enterprises that display animals to paying visitors, sometimes incorporating conservation or educational activities alongside entertainment functions.

- **Sanctuaries**, by contrast, are dedicated to the protection and care of animals, without breeding, trading, or exploiting them for profit. Whilst some may allow visitors, animal interests must always take precedence.

Given the blurred boundaries between these categories, regulatory focus should be directed toward the underlying purpose of the institution - whether it exists primarily for animals or for commercial gain.

Conservation Considerations

Although zoos often claim to contribute to conservation, and prevent some species from extinction, evidence suggests that only a small proportion of their resources is directed

[1] Contributions of zoos and aquariums to reintroductions: historical reintroduction efforts in the context of changing conservation perspectives - Gilbert - 2017 - International Zoo Yearbook - Wiley Online Library

An analysis of zoo visitors' favourite and least favourite animals - ScienceDirect

toward meaningful conservation outcomes.[2] Furthermore, most animals held in captivity are not endangered and reintroduction programmes are limited in scope and success.[3]

Captive environments cannot replicate the complexity of natural ecosystems and animals bred in such conditions frequently struggle to survive when released.[4] This raises serious questions about the effectiveness and ethical justification of captivity based conservation models.

Animal Welfare Concerns

Confinement in artificial environments can lead to significant physical and psychological harm. Many captive animals exhibit signs of distress, including repetitive behaviours, self-harm, and abnormal aggression. In some cases, these symptoms are managed pharmacologically rather than addressed at their source.[5]

Additionally, practices such as the killing of “surplus” animals highlight the commodification inherent in zoo systems.[6] Even in well-resourced facilities, captivity restricts animals’ ability to engage in natural behaviours, form social bonds and exercise autonomy.[7]

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[2] J Keulartz (2015), Captivity for Conservation? Zoos at a Crossroads | Journal of Agricultural and Environmental Ethics | Springer Nature Link (2015) 28 335-351
S Coghlan and APA Cardilini *A critical review of the compassionate conservation debate* Conservation Biology (2022) 36(1) e1376 https://doi.org/10.1002/cobi.13760.In defence of zoos: how captivity helps conservation
How many bird and mammal extinctions has recent conservation action prevented?
Zoos: Financing Conservation or Funding Captivity? - Born Free

[3] https://zslpublications.onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/abs/10.1111/izy.12159
Most Captive-Born Predators Die If Released | National Geographic

[4] Animals bred in captivity develop physical changes that may hinder survival in the wild, research finds | Australia news | The Guardian

[5] https://www.nytimes.com/2021/06/11/opinion/zoos-animal-cruelty.html
https://bioone.org/journals/journal-of-zoo-and-wildlife-medicine/volume-50/issue-4/2018-0147/THE-USE-OF-CITALOPRAM-HYDROBROMIDE-TO-MANAGE-AGGRESSION-IN-A/10.1638/2018-0147.short

[6] Killing Healthy Animals in Zoos: "Zoothanasia" is a Reality | Psychology Today

[7] Influence of enclosure size on the distances covered and paced by captive tigers (Panthera tigris) - ScienceDirect
Slow violence against animals: Unseen spectacles in racing and at zoos - ScienceDirect

Education and Public Engagement

Claims that zoos provide meaningful conservation education are not strongly supported by evidence.[8] Visitor engagement is often driven by leisure and social interaction rather than learning and any educational benefits are typically limited.

Emerging technologies offer a more effective and ethical pathway. Virtual and immersive experiences can foster understanding of animals and ecosystems without subjecting animals to captivity.[9] These approaches also allow for broader accessibility and adaptability.

To maintain credibility as educational institutions, facilities must also align their practices, such as food offering, with principles of sustainability and animal protection.

Related Policies and Positions

Eliminating the Use of Animals in Entertainment Policy
Protection of Indigenous and Non-Indigenous Wild Animals
Legislation and Regulation Reform for Animal Protection Policy

Further Reading

- Code of Welfare – Zoos
- Standards of Modern Zoo Practice for Great Britain (May 2025)
- Animal welfare rules in British zoos set for major overhaul - GOV.UK
- Standards of Modern Zoo Practice for Great Britain – Recent Update | A-LAW
- Standards of Modern Zoo Practice for Great Britain (to take effect from 24 May 2027)

[8] NV Nygren and S Ojalammi *Conservation education in zoos: A literature review* TRACE ∴ Journal for Human-Animal Studies (2017) 4 62-76 https://doi.org/10.23984/fjhas.66540 and S Clayton, J Fraser and C Burgess *The Role of Zoos in Fostering Environmental Identity* Ecopsychology (2011) 3(2) https://doi.org/10.1089/eco.2010.0079.
[9] A Case Study Exploring the Use of Virtual Reality in the Zoo Context — Animal Behavior and Cognition Launch of Europe's first virtual zoo | Eurogroup for Animals